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BUDDING ENTREPRENEURS FORUM

VENTURES VOYAGE

BUDDING ENTREPRENEURS FORUM

SEPTEMBER-2025

BEYOND IT & STARTUPS

INDIA'S OVERLOOKED SECTORS

INTRODUCTION

India is often praised for its strong IT sector, fast-growing startups, and manufacturing that matches the best in the world. However, behind these well-known achievements, some industries are not as widely recognized. These industries are deeply rooted in Indian culture, economy, and society. They provide jobs to many people and have the power to change consumer markets and how the world sees Indian businesses.

From secondhand clothing that's becoming popular because of Gen Z's eco-friendly choices, to the ancient lac industry that supports rural artisans and exports globally, these stories show how tradition and modernity can come together.

The wooden toys made in Channapatna keep local communities alive, and the leather industry in Dharavi, despite long-held stereotypes, remains one of Asia's largest leather producers and is a major exporter.

This edition aims to shine a light on these promising industries -ones that are often ignored in mainstream discussions but are rich in history, resilience, and untapped potential.

By looking at these sectors, we not only recognize their importance to India's economy but also highlight the creativity and diversity that exist in everyday parts of the country.

Written By:
Khushi Sethia
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KERALA COIR INDUSTRY

Coconut to commerce

Beneath coconut palms and the serene backwaters of Kerala, there is an industry that silently weaves its path to world markets, the Coir industry. Passed over in discussions regarding India's upcoming industries, the coir cluster of Kerala is a beacon of hope for how traditional craftsmanship can employ people, support communities, and be recognized internationally.

Kerala is famous for manufacturing an array of coir products ranging from ropes, mats, brushes, and mattresses to nature-friendly handicrafts. Prices vary from approximately ₹100 to ₹500 for minor items such as mats and brushes, whereas high-end products such as mattresses and designer handicrafts are above ₹5,000, making them within the reach of the local population while being of international standards. The extent of variety and strength in these products makes Kerala coir extremely popular locally and internationally.

The sector employs more than 700,000 workers, mostly in rural districts, and has a market capitalization estimated at close to $400 million. Its scale is not only impressive but also how far-reaching it is: goods made in small-scale workshops and homes end up in shops throughout Europe, North America, the Middle East, and Japan. Kerala coir meets international quality, but the craftspeople and their tales are not well known.

This underground giant shows how India's untapped industries have the power to influence the world. Identifying and empowering such industries can open doors to future growth while empowering groups of people who are usually behind the scenes.

Written By:
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CHANNA PATNA WOODEN TOYS

A Silent Powerhouse

In the quiet village of Channapatna, Karnataka, thrives a centuries-old craft that remains one of India's most underappreciated industries—lacquered wooden toys. While today's toy markets are dominated by plastic imports, Channapatna's handcrafted, sustainable toys continue to sustain livelihoods and charm global buyers. These toys are made from locally available wood and coated with natural dyes, ensuring safety and durability. The range includes dolls, figurines, puzzles, utility items, and home décor, priced from ₹100 to ₹2,000. Their craftsmanship has earned them the Geographical Indication (GI) tag, underlining their cultural and artisanal significance.

Nearly 5,000 artisans are engaged in this industry, which has a market size of over ₹200 crore annually. Channapatna toys are exported to Europe and the United States, and supplied to major retailers such as IKEA. Social enterprises like Varnam Craft Collective and Maya Organic have modernized designs while keeping traditional techniques alive.

Yet, despite global demand, most artisans remain invisible, with middlemen and international brands reaping greater recognition. With branding, innovation, and market support, Channapatna's toy industry could transform into a global leader—proving how India's hidden industries can combine heritage with economic power.

Written By:
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AN UPCOMING BUSINESS BEHEMOTH

AI Consultancy

Artificial Intelligence(AI) has transformed many industries, yet the majority of organizations still fail to utilize it efficiently. That is where AI consultants step in. An AI consultant helps organizations find out how to utilize AI, which tools are best suited, and how to get it up and running seamlessly. They are action partners, filling the gap between innovative technology and the actual requirements of organizations.

Demand for AI consulting will increase exponentially. Businesses are aware that AI can enhance productivity, automate processes, and fuel innovation, but do not have the inhouse talent. As worldwide AI adoption speeds up, businesses will need professionals who can implement tailored AI solutions, implement responsibly, and provide measurable ROI. General IT consultants are not doing the trick: AI consultants need technical skills, business strategy, and industry knowledge, making this position extremely valuable and specialized.

As AI is used more and more in healthcare, finance, manufacturing and small businesses, AI consulting will become a multi billion dollar industry. The future belongs to those who will facilitate organizations in making this transition so that AI is not just a tool but a differentiator.

In short, AI consulting is not simply an emerging trend, its a coming business behemoth.

Written By:
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THE UNSEEN TREASURE

India's Lac Industry

Those colorful bangles you adorn, the glossy sheen on wooden furniture, or even the shining coat on some fruits and sweets, all of them could have a silent partner in common: lac. A natural resin exuded by the tiny Kerria lacca insect, lac, has been a part of Indian culture for centuries, but hardly anyone is aware of it. Interestingly, India produces the most lac in the world, with over 90% of the world's production.

Lac is grown primarily in states such as Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, West Bengal, and Madhya Pradesh, where tribal populations rely on it as their mainstay. After it has been harvested, it is utilized in the manufacture of items like bangles, dyes, varnishes, and polishes. Apart from conventional applications, purified lac, in the form of shellac, is used in the food industry and the pharma industry as a natural coating and even in Ayurveda for its medicinal value.

Though it has extensive applications and worldwide demand, India's lac industry is undetected and unorganized in general. Urban consumers lack information about its existence, though they use products handled by lac daily.

With increasing international demand for sustainable and environmentally friendly options, lac has huge potential to emerge as a successful industry. Not only does it protect cultural heritage, but it also gives empowerment to rural communities, particularly women artisans, who have been the keepers of this craft for generations.

Written By:
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DHARAVI LEATHER

An Unexplored Giant

Deep within Mumbai's narrow, plain, unstructured housing and boundless throngs is a business that has reconfigured, unobtrusively, not just Dharavi's economy but also India's international trade—the leather industry. Frequently ignored in the debate regarding India's emerging sectors, Dharavi's leather cluster is a dramatic demonstration of how untapped industries have the potential to create employment as well as international acknowledgment.

Dharavi is famous for the mass production of leather products, including jackets, shoes, belts, bags, wallets, and accessories. Their prices range from around ₹500 to ₹700 for products like wallets and belts, and jackets, and others are more than ₹5,000, making them affordable for locals while maintaining export quality. The variety of products and craftsmanship quality make Dharavi leather highly sought after in markets locally as well as globally.

The leather industry here has over 20,000 employees and has reached a market capitalization of nearly $250 million. What is remarkable about this industry is not so much its size but its penetration; products made in these small sheds find their way into retail outlets across Europe, the Middle East, North America, and Japan. Products made in Dharavi are equal to international brands, though their story remains unknown. This secret giant illustrates how India's untapped sectors can lead the world. Identifying such sectors can unlock future opportunities for expansion while empowering communities that are too often left in the shadows.

Written By:
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THRIFT & RESALE FASHION

The Often-Unnoticed Gen Z Business Revolution

You've undoubtedly seen an Instagram page offering a repurposed dress, a vintage denim jacket, or branded sneakers for half of their original cost. What appears to be a casual scroll is actually the emergence of thrift and resale fashion, one of the fastest-growing but frequently overlooked business trends among Gen Z.

For this generation, fashion is about making thoughtful decisions rather than just looking good. They are eschewing the "buy-wear-dispose" mentality and adopting thrift as a sustainable and fashionable statement. They prolong the life of clothing, cut down on textile waste, and support a circular economy by buying used.

Surprisingly, this industry rarely makes headlines in comparison to high-profile sectors like luxury fashion or e-commerce, despite the fact that it is booming and is expected to surpass traditional retail in the years to come. Behind the scenes, major platforms are expanding into international markets, and small business owners are transforming Instagram pages into profitable endeavors.

Thrift and resale fashion is a quiet revolution that is inexpensive, profitable, and environmentally friendly. Despite frequently going unnoticed, Gen Z is demonstrating that this underappreciated sector has the potential to completely change the retail landscape.

Written By:
Vedashree Ghotkar
MBA - HR

R.I.D.E. 2025

Ideas, Innovation, and Impact

INNOVATION ENTREPRENEURSHIP
R.I.D.E.25
RESEARCH DESIGN

From 11th to 14th August, MIT-WPU hosted its flagship event, R.I.D.E. (Research, Innovation, Design, and Entrepreneurship) 2025, turning the campus into a vibrant hub of ideas and inspiration. Organised by the Budding Entrepreneurs Forum, the four-day conclave brought together students, mentors, and industry leaders to celebrate creativity, innovation, and the future of entrepreneurship.

Each day carried a distinct theme: Research, Innovation, Design, and Entrepreneurship, giving the event a clear direction and flow. Discussions explored artificial intelligence, sustainable business practices, evolving workplaces, design thinking, leadership, and the essentials of building startups.

The sessions came across as honest and relatable, far beyond just bookish concepts. Speakers shared their personal journeys with both successes and failures. Students saw how classroom lessons can actually connect to real life. It built a sense of confidence to try out their own ideas.

A key moment of the event was the Mentor–Mentee sessions. They stood out because they created a space for open talks, honest guidance, and real connection between students and experts. These interactions were great opportunities for the Budding Entrepreneurs Forum to discuss their ideas, identify gaps in the market, and receive personal guidance on building impactful businesses.

R.I.D.E. 2025 became a stage where ideas and experiences met. Students listened to leaders from technology and young startups who shared not just their wins, but also the lessons learned on the way. Real case studies and simple strategies made the sessions practical, not just inspiring. What stood out was the repeated reminder that the future will belong to those who think differently, stay flexible, and move ahead with courage.

More than just a campus program, R.I.D.E. 2025 grew into a powerful movement. It became a space where ideas were not only discussed but also transformed into actions, leaving participants with confidence and purpose.

R.I.D.E. 2025

Ideas, Innovation, and Impact

Written By:
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UNEXPLORED INDUSTRIES IN INDIA

The Next Big Opportunity

When we talk about India's growth story, we instantly think of IT, startups, or large-scale manufacturing. But here's something most people miss: some of the most exciting opportunities lie in industries no one's talking about yet. These are the quiet game-changer industries that have the potential to redefine our economy in the coming years.

Take sustainable packaging, for example. With people becoming more eco-conscious and regulations pushing for greener alternatives, the demand for biodegradable and recyclable packaging is exploding. Yet, this industry is still young, perfect for innovators to step in.

Then there's waste-to-energy. India produces mountains of waste every single day, but only a tiny fraction is converted into energy. Imagine the impact of cleaner cities and a steady source of renewable power. That's a win-win waiting to happen.
And let's not forget medical tourism. India already attracts patients for affordable, quality healthcare. But with the right infrastructure and global outreach, this could become one of our strongest exports.

Beyond these, drone technology in agriculture, plant-based protein, and space-tech startups are all on the rise thanks to ISRO's support and a growing appetite for innovation.

India is on the path to becoming a $5 trillion economy. These unexplored industries are the hidden engines that can take us there. For those ready to look beyond the obvious, the question isn't if these sectors will boom; it's who will lead the way.

Written By:
Vishal Ishwale
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WHAT'S HAPPENING IN THE ENTREPRENEURIAL WORLD

1.Parallel

"Parag Agrawal's AI Comeback Aims to Outperform GPT-5"

Former Twitter CEO Parag Agrawal, with his new AI business, Parallel, has returned to the forefront of entrepreneurship and is already creating a stir. Supported by about 260 crores in investment, Parallel asserts that their platform can achieve 10% more accuracy in real-world applications than OpenAI's GPT-5. The startup is developing models that can comprehend, contextualize, and react more intelligently rather than just extracting data from the internet -a step closer to "true machine reasoning." This isn't your average AI test. Parallel has immediately drawn significant investor attention and early partnerships thanks to Agrawal's reputation for technical expertise and extensive global networks. The timing is impeccable. AI adoption is surging in industries from healthcare to logistics, yet most enterprises still wrestle with reliability and trust in large language models. Parallel's promise to close that gap is bold, but it positions the company as one of the few Indian-linked players competing at the highest level in global AI development.

2. Akasa

"Akasa Banks ₹1,200 Crore Fuel to Soar Higher"

Akasa, India's most recent airline, has raised $1,200 billion in new capital, which clearly indicates that investors believe in its long-term plan. Premji Invest, 360 One Asset, Ranjan Pai's investment office, and the Jhunjhunwala family, who were early supporters, continued to support the series. Akasa has rapidly grown to more than 120 daily flights and competes with industry titans such as IndiGo and Air India, although it entered one of the most competitive markets, aviation, only three years ago. The additional funds are expected to support international routes, fleet expansion, and technological improvements aimed at improving passenger satisfaction and operational effectiveness. This injection shows an opinion that the aviation industry in India is poised for explosive expansion as middle-class travel demand increases, although the airline is currently facing financial losses in the early stages.

3. Gladful

"Nutrition Brand Gladful Snacks on ₹8 Crore Funding"
Eternal Capital led a new funding round of 8 million for Gladful's clean-label nutrition company, together with Antler India, Venture Catalysts, and other angel investors. Gladful was founded to produce nutritiou,s high-protein snacks for families and children. The company's continuous growth in the direct consumer sector has been realized by integrating nutritional research with attractive children's products such as cookies and spreads. With this funding, the company can expand its product range, improve distribution through physical and online channels, and strengthen brand awareness in India's competitive packaged food market. Gladful differentiates itself by achieving harmony between taste and wellness in a market that is often saturated with products high in sugar or additives.

Written By:
Sanjana Kashyap
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WHY MARKETING EXPERIENCE CAN'T WAIT UNTIL GRADUATION

To the new members joining the Budding Entrepreneurs Forum, welcome to a space where your marketing journey can begin today, not years from now. Many students wait until graduation or internships to explore marketing, but by then, valuable time is already lost. Real learning starts when you get your hands dirty early.

Our branding team is not just another college committee - it is structured like a professional marketing agency. Here, you will work on live projects, collaborate with real brands, and see the direct impact of your ideas. This is where portfolios are built, confidence is developed, and industry-ready skills are sharpened long before you step into the corporate world.

Every post, campaign, or strategy you contribute to is a step toward becoming more than just a student - it makes you a marketer with experience that speaks louder than theory. The earlier you start, the stronger your edge will be.As you step in, bring your curiosity, creativity, and hunger to learn. The forum will give you opportunities, but it's your energy that will define your growth. Together, we're building something far bigger than ourselves.Miles to go before we sleep.

Written By:
Sohira Kshemkalyani
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CONCLUSION

As we reach the end of this edition, it becomes clear that the industries we often overlook are the ones quietly reshaping our economy and society. From the rising wave of thrift fashion embraced by Gen Z, to the bustling entrepreneurial spirit of Dharavi's industries, and the urgent innovation taking place in waste management, each of these spaces is a reminder that opportunity does not always wear a glamorous face. Instead, it thrives in resilience, resourcefulness, and the ability to see value where others see none.

This newsletter set out with a simple goal: to shine a light on these unexplored industries. Too often, they remain unnoticed—overshadowed by mainstream business narratives—yet they hold immense potential for sustainable growth, social impact, and innovation. By bringing them into focus, we hope to spark curiosity, conversations, and perhaps even inspire action among our readers.

The future of business isn't confined to conventional sectors. It lies equally in these hidden powerhouses, where creativity meets necessity, and where new possibilities are constantly being crafted. As we move forward, let's not just admire the obvious success stories but also recognize and support the industries that are quietly driving change behind the scenes.

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Forum Faculty Mentor

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